



No more in the shadows: At the Inter-State Athletics Championships in Bhubaneswar, Ancy leapt 6.88m to erase Anju Bobby George's long-standing national record of 6.83m. BISWARANJAN ROUT

how Sojan prepares herself to compete. Even her spikes come with their own rules. At Bhubaneswar, she had a new pair.

"I have one set that I keep just for competitions. I never take them to the training area," she says. "I wanted that new feeling, an extra something for this competition."

The nails too were chosen to match her blue competition kit. "They're very attractive and you can see them from far away. They make me feel more confident."

On competition mornings, the transformation takes about an hour.

"Doing my makeup on the morning of a competition is like getting ready for me. I feel very cool and relaxed when I do it. I like playing energetic songs that get me hyped up. I'm having fun. I watch long jump videos. I get my hair braided, then I apply eyeliner and lipstick. Finally, I glue on my nails.

"I want to look as beautiful as possible. I want to be someone who can be seen from anywhere."

After her events, she likes to go back and watch herself.

"I'm obsessed with how I look. I'm obsessed with my body and muscles. I love the intensity with which I run down the runway and then take off. I look at my eyes and how focused they are. There's this madness and aggression, and I love seeing that."

There is no embarrassment in that ambition.

Ancy has heard people say she is

showing off. She knows there are those who believe an athlete should simply compete and let the performance speak for itself. But she sees no contradiction between looking good and wanting to be taken seriously. Ancy herself admits to being a fan of long jumper Malaika Mihambo's hoop earrings and sprinter Sha'Carri Richardson's colourful braids. But she is also clear that she is neither adapting nor inventing a persona.

"This is who I am."

Ancy grew up in Nattika, a fishing village on the Arabian Sea in Kerala's Thrissur district. She is the daughter of an autorickshaw driver. Her first coach, too, drove rickshaws. Hers is as modest a background as they come. Yet, there were signs of the personality that would eventually become one of her trademarks.

"I think I've always been this way.